

Jeremiah 4 - 6

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight the warning stops being general and starts being specific - a trumpet in the land, a lion already out of his thicket, and a prophet who cannot get his own heart to stop shaking.

Ground too hard to plant, and a command to break it up before sowing.

A search through a whole city for one honest man, with pardon promised if he can be found.

A refiner working the bellows until the lead is gone, and finding nothing worth keeping.

Jeremiah 4 opens with a genuine offer - if you will return - and then walks steadily into the vision that undoes creation itself: earth waste and void, heavens without light, no man, no birds.

Jeremiah 5 sends Jeremiah into the streets on an errand that reads like Abraham at Sodom, and the failure is total - not because the poor are ignorant, but because the educated broke the yoke too.

Jeremiah 6 brings the siege close enough to hear, and in the middle of it offers the gentlest sentence in the book - stand at the crossroads, ask for the ancient paths, walk in the good way - and records the four words that answer it: we will not walk.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 4 - Break Up the Fallow Ground, and the Undoing of Creation

Key Notes

- The chapter opens with a real offer, stated conditionally twice over: if you will return, and if you will put away your abominations, then you will not be removed (Jeremiah 4:1-2).
- Two agricultural commands frame repentance as work, not feeling: break up ground that has gone hard from disuse, and stop scattering seed where thorns will take it (Jeremiah 4:3).
- “Circumcise yourselves to Yahweh, and take away the foreskins of your heart” - the covenant sign relocated from the body to the will, exactly where Deuteronomy had already put it (Jeremiah 4:4).
- The alarm goes up: trumpet, standard, flight to fortified cities. The destroyer is described as a lion already out of his thicket - not gathering, but travelling (Jeremiah 4:5-8).
- Jeremiah’s protest in verse 10 is startlingly raw. He accuses Yahweh of allowing a deception, because the prophets kept saying peace while the sword reached the heart (Jeremiah 4:9-10).
- Even now the appeal is personal and interior: wash your heart from wickedness, that you may be saved. How long will evil thoughts lodge within you? (Jeremiah 4:14).
- Jeremiah’s grief becomes physical - “my anguish, my anguish! I am pained at my very heart” - the prophet is not delivering a verdict he is glad about (Jeremiah 4:19-21).
- The vision of verses 23-26 walks Genesis 1 backwards: earth waste and void, heavens without light, mountains trembling, no man, no birds, the fruitful field a wilderness. Judgment as de-creation (Jeremiah 4:23-26).
- And then the clause that keeps the book from despair: “yet will I not make a full end” (Jeremiah 4:27-28).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Break Up Your Fallow Ground	Jeremiah 4:3 • Hosea 10:12 • Matthew 13:7
Circumcision of the Heart	Jeremiah 4:4 • Deuteronomy 10:16 • Deuteronomy 30:6
Evil Out of the North	Jeremiah 4:6 • Jeremiah 1:14 • Jeremiah 6:1
“Peace” Promised While the Sword Comes	Jeremiah 4:10 • Ezekiel 13:10 • Jeremiah 6:14
Wash Your Heart From Wickedness	Jeremiah 4:14 • Isaiah 1:16 • James 4:8
Skillful in Evil, Ignorant of Good	Jeremiah 4:22 • Romans 16:19 • Isaiah 5:20
Waste and Void - Creation Undone	Jeremiah 4:23 • Genesis 1:2 • Isaiah 24:19-20
“Yet Will I Not Make a Full End”	Jeremiah 4:27 • Jeremiah 5:18 • Romans 11:5

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Circumcision Made Without Hands	Jeremiah 4:4 • Romans 2:28-29 • Colossians 2:11
The Heart Cleansed From Within	Jeremiah 4:14 • James 4:8 • Hebrews 9:14
Light Commanded Back Into the Darkness	Jeremiah 4:23 • Genesis 1:2 • 2 Corinthians 4:6
The Prophet Who Weeps Over the Verdict	Jeremiah 4:19 • Luke 19:41-44 • Matthew 23:37
A Remnant Preserved by Grace	Jeremiah 4:27 • Romans 11:5 • Isaiah 1:9
Sowing on Ground That Has Been Broken	Jeremiah 4:3 • Matthew 13:23 • Hosea 10:12

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 4 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the conditional call to return, the invasion imagery, and the de-creation vision
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 4](#) - covenant-framed treatment of heart circumcision and the northern invader
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 4](#) - exposition of the fallow-ground command and the Genesis parallels in verses 23-26

Jeremiah 4 - Opening Intro

Notice that this chapter begins with an offer, not a sentence. “If you will return.” Everything that follows - the trumpet, the lion, the hot wind, the vision of an emptied world - stands on the other side of a door that is still open when the chapter starts.

And notice what returning is said to involve. Not a feeling. Two images from a farm. Fallow ground is not bad ground; it is good ground that has been left alone until it set hard. Breaking it up is slow, unglamorous work with a blade. And sowing among thorns is not a failure of seed but a failure to clear.

Then verse 4 moves the knife from the body to the heart, which is where Deuteronomy had aimed it all along. The sign was never meant to stay in the flesh.

The hardest part of this chapter is verses 23 through 26. Jeremiah looks and sees Genesis 1 running backwards - the formless void returning, the light withdrawn, the birds gone. He is telling us what sin actually does when it is allowed to finish: it un-makes.

Before we read, hold this: the same voice that says “waste and void” in verse 23 said “let there be light” over the same waters. Nothing here is beyond His speech.

Jeremiah 4:1-31 (WEB)

1 “If you will return, Israel,” says Yahweh, “if you will return to me, and if you will put away your abominations out of my sight; then you will not be removed;

2 and you will swear, ‘As Yahweh lives,’ in truth, in justice, and in righteousness. The nations will bless themselves in him, and they will glory in him.”

3 For Yahweh says to the men of Judah and to Jerusalem, “Break up your fallow ground, and don’t sow among thorns.”¹

4 Circumcise yourselves to Yahweh, and take away the foreskins of your heart, you men of Judah and inhabitants of Jerusalem; lest my wrath go out like fire, and burn so that no one can quench it, because of the evil of your doings.^{2,3}

5 Declare in Judah, and publish in Jerusalem; and say, ‘Blow the trumpet in the land!’ Cry aloud and say, ‘Assemble yourselves! Let us go into the fortified cities!’

6 Set up a standard toward Zion. Flee for safety! Don’t wait; for I will bring evil from the north, and a great destruction.”

7 A lion has gone up from his thicket, and a destroyer of nations. He is on his way. He has gone out from his place, to make your land desolate, that your cities be laid waste, without inhabitant.

8 For this, clothe yourself with sackcloth, lament and wail; for the fierce anger of Yahweh hasn’t turned back from us.

9 “It will happen at that day,” says Yahweh, “that the heart of the king will perish, along with the heart of the princes. The priests will be astonished, and the prophets will wonder.”

10 Then I said, “Ah, Lord Yahweh! Surely you have greatly deceived this people and Jerusalem, saying, ‘You will have peace;’ whereas the sword reaches to the heart.”⁴

11 At that time it will be said to this people and to Jerusalem, “A hot wind from the bare heights in the wilderness toward the daughter of my people, not to winnow, nor to cleanse;

12 a full wind from these will come for me. Now I will also utter judgments against them.”

13 Behold, he will come up as clouds, and his chariots will be as the whirlwind. His horses are swifter than eagles. Woe to us! For we are ruined.

¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Hosea 10:12](#) - the same command to break up fallow ground, tied to the season for seeking Yahweh

² **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 10:16](#) • [Deuteronomy 30:6](#) - the command to circumcise the heart, and the promise that Yahweh Himself would do it

³ **Messianic Connection:** [Romans 2:28-29](#) • [Colossians 2:11](#) - circumcision of the heart by the Spirit, made without hands in Messiah

⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Ezekiel 13:10](#) - prophets crying peace where there was none, whitewashing a wall that would not stand

14 Jerusalem, wash your heart from wickedness, that you may be saved. How long will your evil thoughts lodge within you?⁵

15 For a voice declares from Dan, and publishes evil from the hills of Ephraim:

16 "Tell the nations; behold, publish against Jerusalem, 'Watchers come from a far country, and raise their voice against the cities of Judah.

17 As keepers of a field, they are against her all around, because she has been rebellious against me,'" says Yahweh.

18 "Your way and your doings have brought these things to you. This is your wickedness; for it is bitter, for it reaches to your heart."

19 My anguish, my anguish! I am pained at my very heart! My heart trembles within me. I can't hold my peace, because you have heard, O my soul, the sound of the trumpet, the alarm of war.⁶

20 Destruction on destruction is decreed, for the whole land is laid waste. Suddenly my tents are destroyed, and my curtains gone in a moment.

21 How long will I see the standard and hear the sound of the trumpet?

22 "For my people are foolish. They don't know me. They are foolish children, and they have no understanding. They are skillful in doing evil, but they don't know how to do good."

23 I saw the earth, and, behold, it was waste and void; and the heavens, and they had no light.^{7,8}

24 I saw the mountains, and behold, they trembled, and all the hills moved back and forth.

25 I saw, and behold, there was no man, and all the birds of the sky had fled.

26 I saw, and behold, the fruitful field was a wilderness, and all its cities were broken down at the presence of Yahweh, before his fierce anger.

27 For Yahweh says, "The whole land will be a desolation; yet will I not make a full end."⁹

28 For this the earth will mourn, and the heavens above be black; because I have spoken it. I have planned it, and I have not repented, neither will I turn back from it."

29 Every city flees for the noise of the horsemen and archers. They go into the thickets, and climb up on the rocks. Every city is forsaken, and not a man dwells therein.

⁵ Cross-Reference: [Isaiah 1:16](#) • [James 4:8](#) - wash, make yourselves clean - and purify your hearts, you double-minded

⁶ Messianic Connection: [Luke 19:41-44](#) - the One who wept over the city He was announcing judgment against

⁷ Cross-Reference: [Genesis 1:2](#) - the formless and empty earth of the first verse, returning as judgment

⁸ Messianic Connection: [2 Corinthians 4:6](#) - the God who said light will shine out of darkness, shining again in human hearts

⁹ Cross-Reference: [Romans 11:5](#) - a remnant preserved according to the election of grace - never a full end

30 You, when you are made desolate, what will you do? Though you clothe yourself with scarlet, though you deck yourself with ornaments of gold, though you enlarge your eyes with makeup, you make yourself beautiful in vain. Your lovers despise you. They seek your life.

31 For I have heard a voice as of a woman in travail, the anguish as of her who gives birth to her first child, the voice of the daughter of Zion, who gasps for breath, who spreads her hands, saying, "Woe is me now! For my soul faints before the murderers."

CHAPTER 5 - Search the Streets for One Just Man

Key Notes

- The chapter opens with an errand that echoes Abraham at Sodom: run through Jerusalem, look everywhere, and if you can find one man who does justly and seeks truth, Yahweh will pardon the city (Jeremiah 5:1-2).
- Correction has failed as a method. They were struck and not grieved, consumed and not taught - faces harder than rock (Jeremiah 5:3).
- Jeremiah's first instinct is charitable: surely these are just the poor, who never had the chance to learn Torah. So he goes to the educated, who certainly know it - and finds they have broken the yoke with one accord. The failure is not literacy (Jeremiah 5:4-5).
- Prosperity is named as the occasion of the betrayal: "when I had fed them to the full, they committed adultery." Fullness, not hunger, was the danger (Jeremiah 5:7-9).
- The people's creed is quoted back at them: "It is not he. Evil will not come on us." Practical atheism dressed as confidence (Jeremiah 5:12-13).
- Because they call the prophets wind, Yahweh makes His words in Jeremiah's mouth fire, and the people wood (Jeremiah 5:14).
- The sand rebukes them. The sea, immeasurably stronger, cannot cross a boundary of loose grains because Yahweh decreed it - and this people, who could obey, will not (Jeremiah 5:22-23).
- The economic charge is specific: houses full of deceit like cages full of birds, grown fat and shining, refusing to plead the cause of the fatherless (Jeremiah 5:26-29).
- The chapter ends by naming the collusion. Prophets prophesy falsely, priests rule by their own authority - and "my people love to have it so." The audience is complicit (Jeremiah 5:30-31).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Searching for One Righteous Man	Jeremiah 5:1 • Genesis 18:23-32 • Ezekiel 22:30
Correction Received in Vain	Jeremiah 5:3 • Jeremiah 2:30 • Proverbs 29:1
Fed to the Full, Then Faithless	Jeremiah 5:7 • Deuteronomy 32:15 • Hosea 13:6
The Word as Fire in the Prophet's Mouth	Jeremiah 5:14 • Jeremiah 23:29 • Jeremiah 20:9
The Sand as a Bound for the Sea	Jeremiah 5:22 • Job 38:8-11 • Psalm 104:9
The Former and the Latter Rain	Jeremiah 5:24 • Deuteronomy 11:14 • Acts 14:17
Justice Denied to the Fatherless	Jeremiah 5:28 • Isaiah 1:23 • Zechariah 7:10
"My People Love to Have It So"	Jeremiah 5:31 • Isaiah 30:10 • 2 Timothy 4:3-4

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The One Righteous Man Who Was Found	Jeremiah 5:1 • Romans 3:10-12 • 2 Corinthians 5:21
The Intercessor Who Stood in the Gap	Jeremiah 5:1 • Ezekiel 22:30 • Hebrews 7:25
Pardon Granted for One Man's Sake	Jeremiah 5:1 • Romans 5:18-19 • Isaiah 53:11
The Word That Burns and Cannot Be Held In	Jeremiah 5:14 • Jeremiah 20:9 • Luke 24:32
Ears That Hear and Eyes That See	Jeremiah 5:21 • Matthew 13:14-16 • Mark 8:18
Itching Ears in Every Generation	Jeremiah 5:31 • 2 Timothy 4:3-4 • Isaiah 30:10

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 5 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the search for a righteous man, the practical atheism of verse 12, and the sea-boundary argument
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 5](#) - treatment of the social-justice charges and the complicity of the people
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 5](#) - exposition of the Abraham-at-Sodom parallel and the false-prophet collusion

Jeremiah 5 - Opening Intro

Abraham once talked Yahweh down from fifty righteous men to ten, and Sodom could not produce ten. Here the number is one. One person in an entire capital city who does justly and seeks truth, and the whole city is pardoned.

What follows is Jeremiah's own reasoning process, and it is worth watching because it is generous. His first thought is that he has been looking in the wrong neighborhood - these are the poor, they were never taught. So he goes where the education is. And the great men have broken the yoke with one accord.

Then comes the argument from the beach. The sea is the most powerful thing an ancient person could imagine, and it is held back by sand. Not a wall - sand. It roars and cannot pass, because Yahweh said so. And a people who could choose obedience will not.

The last verse is the one that should stop us. Jeremiah does not lay the whole thing on corrupt clergy. He says the prophets lie, the priests rule for themselves - and my people love to have it so. Deception on that scale requires a market.

Before we read, carry this honestly: it is worth asking what we have been buying, and why the sellers keep finding us.

Jeremiah 5:1-31 (WEB)

1 “Run back and forth through the streets of Jerusalem, and see now, and know, and seek in its wide places, if you can find a man, if there is anyone who does justly, who seeks truth, then I will pardon her.”^{10,11}

2 Though they say, ‘As Yahweh lives,’ surely they swear falsely.”

3 O Yahweh, don’t your eyes look on truth? You have stricken them, but they were not grieved. You have consumed them, but they have refused to receive correction. They have made their faces harder than a rock. They have refused to return.”¹²

4 Then I said, “Surely these are poor. They are foolish; for they don’t know the way of Yahweh, nor the law of their God.

5 I will go to the great men, and will speak to them; for they know the way of Yahweh, and the law of their God.” But these with one accord have broken the yoke, and burst the bonds.

6 Therefore a lion out of the forest will kill them, a wolf of the evenings will destroy them, a leopard will watch against their cities. Everyone who goes out there will be torn in pieces, because their transgressions are many, and their backsliding has increased.

7 “How can I pardon you? Your children have forsaken me, and sworn by what are no gods. When I had fed them to the full, they committed adultery, and assembled themselves in troops at the prostitutes’ houses.

8 They were as fed horses roaming at large. Everyone neighed after his neighbor’s wife.

9 Shouldn’t I punish them for these things?” says Yahweh. “Shouldn’t my soul be avenged on such a nation as this?

10 “Go up on her walls, and destroy; but don’t make a full end. Take away her branches, for they are not Yahweh’s.

11 For the house of Israel and the house of Judah have dealt very treacherously against me,” says Yahweh.

12 They have denied Yahweh, and said, “It is not he. Evil will won’t come on us. We won’t see sword or famine.

¹⁰ Cross-Reference: [Ezekiel 22:30](#) - Yahweh seeking a man to stand in the gap for the land, and finding no one

¹¹ Messianic Connection: [Romans 3:10-12](#) • [2 Corinthians 5:21](#) - there is none righteous, no not one - until the One who knew no sin was made sin for us

¹² Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 2:30](#) • [Proverbs 29:1](#) - correction refused until the neck stiffens past remedy

13 The prophets will become wind, and the word is not in them. Thus it will be done to them.”

14 Therefore Yahweh, the God of Armies says, “Because you speak this word, behold, I will make my words in your mouth fire, and this people wood, and it will devour them.”¹³

15 Behold, I will bring a nation on you from far away, house of Israel,” says Yahweh. “It is a mighty nation. It is an ancient nation, a nation whose language you don’t know and don’t understand what they say.

16 Their quiver is an open tomb. They are all mighty men.

17 They will eat up your harvest and your bread, which your sons and your daughters should eat. They will eat up your flocks and your herds. They will eat up your vines and your fig trees. They will beat down your fortified cities in which you trust with the sword.

18 “But even in those days,” says Yahweh, “I will not make a full end of you.

19 It will happen, when you say, ‘Why has Yahweh our God done all these things to us?’ Then you shall say to them, ‘Just as you have forsaken me, and served foreign gods in your land, so you will serve strangers in a land that is not yours.’

20 “Declare this in the house of Jacob, and publish it in Judah, saying,

21 ‘Hear this now, foolish people without understanding; who have eyes, and don’t see; who have ears, and don’t hear:

22 Don’t you fear me?’ says Yahweh ‘Won’t you tremble at my presence, who have placed the sand for the bound of the sea, by a perpetual decree, that it can’t pass it? Though its waves toss themselves, yet they can’t prevail. Though they roar, they still can’t pass over it.’¹⁴

23 “But this people has a revolting and a rebellious heart. They have revolted and gone.

24 They don’t say in their heart, ‘Let us now fear Yahweh our God, who gives rain, both the former and the latter, in its season; who preserves to us the appointed weeks of the harvest.’¹⁵

25 “Your iniquities have turned away these things, and your sins have withheld good from you.

26 For among my people are found wicked men. They watch, as fowlers lie in wait. They set a trap. They catch men.

27 As a cage is full of birds, so are their houses full of deceit. Therefore they have become great, and grew rich.

¹³ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 23:29](#) • [Jeremiah 20:9](#) - the word as fire and hammer, and the fire shut up in the prophet’s own bones

¹⁴ Cross-Reference: [Job 38:8-11](#) • [Psalm 104:9](#) - the sea given bars and doors, and a boundary it may not pass

¹⁵ Cross-Reference: [Deuteronomy 11:14](#) - the former and latter rain promised in season to a people who would listen

28 They have grown fat. They shine; yes, they excel in deeds of wickedness. They don't plead the cause, the cause of the fatherless, that they may prosper; and they don't judge the right of the needy.

29 "Shouldn't I punish for these things?" says Yahweh. "Shouldn't my soul be avenged on such a nation as this?"

30 "An astonishing and horrible thing has happened in the land.

31 The prophets prophesy falsely, and the priests rule by their own authority; and my people love to have it so. What will you do in the end of it?^{16,17}

¹⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 30:10](#) - a people who told the seers not to see and asked the prophets for pleasant things

¹⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [2 Timothy 4:3-4](#) - itching ears heaping up teachers to match their own desires

CHAPTER 6 - The Ancient Paths and the Refiner's Failed Fire

Key Notes

- The siege is now audible. Trumpet in Tekoa, signal on Beth Haccherem, an enemy timing his assault by daylight and shadow (Jeremiah 6:1-5).
- The image in verse 7 is exact and awful: as a well keeps producing water, Jerusalem keeps producing her own wickedness. It is not an incident but a spring (Jeremiah 6:6-8).
- The problem is not that they cannot hear but that hearing has become distasteful: the ear is uncircumcised, and Yahweh's word has become a reproach in which they take no delight (Jeremiah 6:10).
- Jeremiah is full of wrath he did not manufacture and is weary with holding in - the prophet carries the message in his body before he delivers it (Jeremiah 6:11).
- The corruption is universal and vertical - least to greatest, prophet to priest, everyone dealing falsely for gain (Jeremiah 6:13).
- The famous diagnosis: they heal the wound of the people superficially, saying "Peace, peace" where there is no peace. A dressing applied over an untreated injury (Jeremiah 6:14-15).
- Then the gentlest offer in the book - stand at the crossroads, look, ask for the ancient paths, walk in the good way, and find rest for your souls - answered with four words: "We will not walk" (Jeremiah 6:16).
- Costly imported worship is rejected outright. Frankincense from Sheba and sweet cane from far away cannot substitute for listening (Jeremiah 6:19-20).
- The chapter ends at the refiner's furnace. The bellows blow, the lead is consumed, the refining goes on and on - and the wicked are not separated out. They are named rejected silver (Jeremiah 6:27-30).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Uncircumcised Ear	Jeremiah 6:10 • Acts 7:51 • Isaiah 6:9-10
Covetousness From Prophet to Priest	Jeremiah 6:13 • Micah 3:11 • Isaiah 56:11
"Peace, Peace," When There Is No Peace	Jeremiah 6:14 • Ezekiel 13:10 • Jeremiah 8:11
Ask for the Ancient Paths	Jeremiah 6:16 • Isaiah 30:21 • Proverbs 22:28
Watchmen Set and Ignored	Jeremiah 6:17 • Ezekiel 33:2-6 • Habakkuk 2:1
Sacrifice Without Obedience	Jeremiah 6:20 • 1 Samuel 15:22 • Micah 6:6-8
The Tester of Metals	Jeremiah 6:27 • Malachi 3:2-3 • Zechariah 13:9
Silver Become Dross	Jeremiah 6:30 • Isaiah 1:22 • Ezekiel 22:18-20

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Rest for Your Souls in the Good Way	Jeremiah 6:16 • Matthew 11:28-30 • Isaiah 30:21
The Wound Healed Deeply, Not Superficially	Jeremiah 6:14 • Isaiah 53:5 • 1 Peter 2:24
Obedience Better Than Sacrifice	Jeremiah 6:20 • 1 Samuel 15:22 • Hebrews 10:5-7
The Refiner Who Sits and Purifies	Jeremiah 6:27-29 • Malachi 3:2-3 • 1 Peter 1:7
Ears Opened to Hear	Jeremiah 6:10 • Acts 7:51 • Romans 10:17
The Stone of Stumbling	Jeremiah 6:21 • Isaiah 8:14 • 1 Peter 2:8

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 6 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the siege oracle, the ancient-paths invitation, and the refiner's furnace image
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 6](#) - Torah-honoring reading of the sacrifice-versus-obedience section
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 6](#) - detailed notes on the false peace of verse 14 and the assaying metaphor

Jeremiah 6 - Opening Intro

Verse 16 is the heart of this chapter, and it is worth slowing down for. Yahweh does not thunder here. He gives four quiet imperatives: stand, look, ask, walk. Stop moving. Look at where the roads go. Ask which one is the good way - the tested one, the old one. Then walk in it.

And the promise attached is not victory or prosperity. It is rest for your souls. The same phrase Yahshua will later use almost word for word when He invites the burdened to come to Him.

The answer is four words long. "We will not walk." No argument, no counter-proposal. Just refusal.

The rest of the chapter shows what refusal costs. Physicians who bandage a wound they never cleaned, saying peace where there is none. Expensive imported incense offered by people who will not listen. And at the end, a refiner working the bellows until the lead burns away, and nothing precious emerges.

Before we read, sit with the invitation before you sit with the verdict. The ancient paths are still there. The question the chapter puts to us is not whether the good way exists, but whether we will stand still long enough to ask for it.

Jeremiah 6:1-30 (WEB)

1 “Flee for safety, you children of Benjamin, out of the middle of Jerusalem! Blow the trumpet in Tekoa and raise up a signal on Beth Haccherem, for evil looks out from the north with a great destruction.

2 I will cut off the beautiful and delicate one, the daughter of Zion.

3 Shepherds with their flocks will come to her. They will pitch their tents against her all around. They will feed everyone in his place.”

4 “Prepare war against her! Arise, and let us go up at noon. Woe to us! For the day declines, for the shadows of the evening are stretched out.

5 Arise, and let us go up by night, and let us destroy her palaces.”

6 For Yahweh of Armies said, “Cut down trees, and cast up a mound against Jerusalem. This is the city to be visited. She is wholly oppression within herself.

7 As a well produces its waters, so she produces her wickedness. Violence and destruction is heard in her. Sickness and wounds are continually before me.

8 Be instructed, Jerusalem, lest my soul be alienated from you; lest I make you a desolation, an uninhabited land.”

9 Yahweh of Armies says, “They will thoroughly glean the remnant of Israel like a vine. Turn again your hand as a grape gatherer into the baskets.”

10 To whom should I speak and testify, that they may hear? Behold, their ear is uncircumcised, and they can’t listen. Behold, Yahweh’s word has become a reproach to them. They have no delight in it.¹⁸

11 Therefore I am full of Yahweh’s wrath. I am weary with holding it in. “Pour it out on the children in the street, and on the assembly of young men together; for even the husband with the wife will be taken, the aged with him who is full of days.

12 Their houses will be turned to others, their fields and their wives together; for I will stretch out my hand on the inhabitants of the land, says Yahweh.”

13 “For from their least even to their greatest, everyone is given to covetousness. From the prophet even to the priest, everyone deals falsely.¹⁹

14 They have healed also the hurt of my people superficially, saying, ‘Peace, peace!’ when there is no peace.^{20,21}

¹⁸ Cross-Reference: [Acts 7:51](#) - Stephen using the same charge - uncircumcised in heart and ears, always resisting the Spirit

¹⁹ Cross-Reference: [Micah 3:11](#) - leaders judging for bribes and priests teaching for a price, while still leaning on Yahweh

²⁰ Cross-Reference: [Ezekiel 13:10](#) - the false peace that whitewashes a wall instead of rebuilding it

²¹ Messianic Connection: [Isaiah 53:5](#) - the wound healed at its root, by stripes borne on behalf of the wounded

15 Were they ashamed when they had committed abomination? No, they were not at all ashamed, neither could they blush. Therefore they will fall among those who fall. When I visit them, they will be cast down," says Yahweh.

16 Yahweh says, "Stand in the ways and see, and ask for the old paths, 'Where is the good way?' and walk in it, and you will find rest for your souls. But they said, 'We will not walk in it.' ^{22,23}

17 I set watchmen over you, saying, 'Listen to the sound of the trumpet!' But they said, 'We will not listen!'

18 Therefore hear, you nations, and know, congregation, what is among them.

19 Hear, earth! Behold, I will bring evil on this people, even the fruit of their thoughts, because they have not listened to my words; and as for my law, they have rejected it.

20 To what purpose does frankincense from Sheba come to me, and the sweet cane from a far country? Your burnt offerings are not acceptable, and your sacrifices are not pleasing to me." ^{24,25}

21 Therefore Yahweh says, "Behold, I will lay stumbling blocks before this people. The fathers and the sons together will stumble against them. The neighbor and his friend will perish."

22 Yahweh says, "Behold, a people comes from the north country. A great nation will be stirred up from the uttermost parts of the earth.

23 They take hold of bow and spear. They are cruel, and have no mercy. Their voice roars like the sea, and they ride on horses, everyone set in array, as a man to the battle, against you, daughter of Zion."

24 We have heard its report. Our hands become feeble. Anguish has taken hold of us, and pains as of a woman in labor.

25 Don't go out into the field, nor walk by the way; for the sword of the enemy and terror are on every side.

26 Daughter of my people, clothe yourself with sackcloth, and wallow in ashes! Mourn, as for an only son, most bitter lamentation, for the destroyer will suddenly come on us.

27 "I have made you a tester of metals and a fortress among my people, that you may know and try their way." ²⁶

28 They are all grievous rebels, going around to slander. They are brass and iron. All of them deal corruptly.

²² **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 30:21](#) - the voice behind you saying, this is the way, walk in it

²³ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 11:28-30](#) - the same promise of rest for your souls, offered to all who labor and are burdened

²⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [1 Samuel 15:22](#) • [Micah 6:6-8](#) - obedience better than sacrifice, and what Yahweh actually requires

²⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 10:5-7](#) - sacrifice not desired, but a body prepared and a will surrendered

²⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Malachi 3:2-3](#) • [Zechariah 13:9](#) - the refiner who sits over the silver, and the third part brought through the fire

29 The bellows blow fiercely. The lead is consumed in the fire. In vain they go on refining, for the wicked are not plucked away.

30 Men will call them rejected silver, because Yahweh has rejected them." ^{27,28}

²⁷ Cross-Reference: [Isaiah 1:22](#) • [Ezekiel 22:18-20](#) - silver become dross, gathered into the furnace

²⁸ Messianic Connection: [1 Peter 1:7](#) - faith tested by fire and found to result in praise, glory, and honor

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 4-6

- Repentance as labor, not sentiment - hard ground broken open before any seed goes in
- The covenant sign moved from the flesh to the heart, where Deuteronomy always aimed it
- Judgment as de-creation: the light withdrawn and the void returning, over the same waters where light was first spoken
- A pardon offered for the sake of one righteous man, and a city that could not produce him
- Prosperity as the occasion of betrayal - fed to the full, and unfaithful because of it
- The sea held back by sand, obeying a decree that a reasoning people refuse
- False peace as malpractice - a dressing laid over a wound nobody cleaned
- The ancient paths still standing open, with rest for the soul promised to whoever will walk them
- A refining fire that cannot produce silver when there is nothing precious left in the ore
- "Yet will I not make a full end" - the remnant clause that keeps every threat from being final

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who commands us to break up our fallow ground give us the patience for slow work, and may we stop scattering good seed into thorns we have not troubled to clear.

May He take the knife to our hearts rather than our habits, and may our obedience run deeper than anything that can be seen from outside.

May He guard us from the comfort of false peace, and give us friends honest enough to refuse to bandage what still needs cleaning.

May He make us the one He is looking for when He searches a street - not for our sake, but for the sake of everyone the searching might spare.

May He teach us to stand still at the crossroads long enough to ask, and may we not answer His kindest invitation with the four hardest words a people ever said.

May He bring us through whatever fire is needed, and may there be silver in us when the lead is gone.

And may every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.